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Hands-On-Learning: The Incident Response & Recovery Sprint

Learning Objectives

By the end of this activity, learners will be able to:



- Draft a structured Incident Response and Recovery Plan covering the key phases of the IR lifecycle.
- Define recovery priorities, communication protocols, and backup strategies for a ransomware scenario.
- Formulate post-incident Lessons Learned across technical, process, and people domains to strengthen future organizational resilience.

Description

In this hands-on activity, learners will experience the high-pressure environment of incident response. Following a simulated ransomware infection on a virtual file server, learners must quickly contain the threat, eradicate the malicious script, and recover the lost data, emphasizing actionable recovery over panic.

Structure of the Activity: Title: The Incident Response & Recovery Sprint

Tools used: Word processing software; IR Plan Template (provided); NIST SP 800-61 Incident Handling Guide (reference)

Scenario

It is 4:00 AM. A ransomware script has executed on your organization's localized virtual file server, encrypting a folder of critical logistics documents. As the Incident Response Lead, you must follow the formal IR lifecycle to contain the damage, clean the system, and restore the business to operational status as quickly as possible.

Objective

Your goal is to produce a concise but complete IR and Recovery Plan that covers all four elements required for organizational resilience: incident response steps, recovery priorities, communication protocols, and backup strategies. This exercise will help you think strategically under pressure and apply the resilience planning concepts covered across this module.



Instructions for learners

1 **IR Plan Draft - Containment & Eradication:**

Identify the infected system and define the specific containment action you would take first (e.g., isolating the virtual network interface) and explain why this step comes before eradication.

Outline the eradication steps required to fully remove the ransomware script from the environment before any recovery begins.
Specify two checks you would perform to confirm the environment is clean before proceeding to recovery.

Identify who on the team is responsible for each containment and eradication action.

2 IR Plan Draft — Recovery and Continuity:

Define your recovery priorities: which system or data set must be restored first and why, applying business continuity principles.

Describe your backup strategy: identify the backup type you would use (e.g., offline snapshot following the 3-2-1 rule), confirm how you would verify it is uncompromised, and state your recovery time target.

Draft a brief communication protocol covering who is notified first (internal stakeholders, legal, regulators), what information is shared at each stage, and through which channel — noting that internal email may also be compromised.

Identify any compliance obligations triggered by this incident, such as data breach notification timelines.

3 Reflection — Lessons Learned:

Identify the specific vulnerability that allowed the ransomware script to execute (e.g., unpatched system, phishing entry point, insufficient endpoint protection).

Write three post-incident recommendations: one addressing the technical control gap, one addressing a process or policy gap, and one addressing a people or training gap.

State one metric you would track over the next 90 days to confirm that resilience has measurably improved as a result of these changes.

Organize Information Following This Structure for Peer Review:

- **Title Page:** Activity title, your name, date.
- **IR Process Overview:** Detail the specific steps taken to contain and eradicate the threat.
- **Recovery Validation:** Describe the process of restoring the snapshot and how you verified the system was clean before reconnecting it to the network.
- **Reflections and Lessons Learned:** Provide a 3-point post-incident review to improve the organization's resilience for the next attack.

Instructions for Documenting and Sharing the Project for Peer Review

Document the Project

- Use word processing software to create your project summary and reflections.
- Ensure all sections of the project document structure are completed.
- Proofread and edit your report for clarity and accuracy.

Share the Project

- Save your report in PDF format.
- Upload your documents to the “Peer Review” area in the course shell.
- Provide a brief description of your project in the submission post.

Peer Review

- Review the plans submitted by your peers.
- Provide constructive feedback and comments on the logical sequence of their IR steps, the realism of their communication protocol, and the quality of their Lessons Learned recommendations.

This activity gives learners a chance to apply the lesson by producing the kind of structured IR and recovery plan that a real Incident Response Lead would be expected to deliver under pressure — covering not just the technical steps but the communication, continuity, and improvement elements that determine whether an organization truly recovers.